

FOR DAVID

The highlands

December 2–7, 2026

San Salvador → Xela → Antigua → home

Five nights in Quetzaltenango. Two Pullmantur buses. A private driver for the days in between. The lake is a lookout, not a hotel. Georginas is lunch, not a soak.

Cover: Parque Centroamérica, Quetzaltenango. Photo by Apoxyomenus, CC BY-SA 4.0.

The week in one look

Xela is the base. Everything else is a day out and back, except Monday, when we leave for good.

Wed 2	Bus from San Salvador. Straight through to Xela. Sleep at Casa Morasan.
Thu 3	Chichicastenango market. Lake view from Sololá. Do not go down to Panajachel.
Fri 4	Hill towns: San Francisco El Alto, San Cristóbal, Totonicapán, Salcajá. Sunset on El Baúl.
Sat 5	Short hike on Cerro Quemado. Then vegetables, a shrine, lunch at the springs, coffee at Las Cumbres.
Sun 6	Chicabal, the real hike. Crafts in town after. The yellow church only if our legs agree.
Mon 7	Two hours in Antigua. Bus home at 2:00. San Benito around 7:30.

What this trip is not

- Not a night in Antigua on the way in, and not a night in Sololá or Panajachel.
- Not Huehuetenango, and not the Santiaguito volcano hike.
- Not a soak. At Georginas we eat and look. At Las Cumbres we drink coffee in the garden.

Wednesday, December 2

A bus day that still ends in Xela. Compression socks. DUI in a pocket, not in the suitcase.

> 5:30 at the Sheraton. Bus at 6:00. Guatemala City late morning. Xela around 4:00–5:00, before the 5:35 sunset. If the border runs so late that the mountain pass would be in the dark, we stop. Otherwise we keep going.

No separate photo.

Tickets: WhatsApp +503 7736-9490.

LONG-DISTANCE BUS

Pullmantur, Primera

Hotel Sheraton Presidente, Colonia San Benito. Be there at 5:30.

This is a coach to Guatemala City, not a tourist shuttle. Primera is the nicer cabin. The ride is about five hours, including the border. Same company, same class, brings us home on Monday at 2:00pm from the Holiday Inn in Zona 10.

pullmantur.com — schedules

No separate photo.

Use the link.

BORDER CROSSING

Las Chinamas / Valle Nuevo

Everyone gets off the bus.

El Salvador on one side, Guatemala on the other. We walk through both migration windows and get back on the same bus. A DUI is enough. Do not change money here, and do not hand the passport to anyone who is not in the window.

migracion.gob.sv



Photo: Jun Aj Pu, CC BY-SA 4.0. Wikimedia.

MOUNTAIN PASS — WE DRIVE THROUGH

Cumbre de Alaska

On the highway west of Los Encuentros, before Xela.

This is not a stop. It is the high pass on the road into Xela, around 3,000 meters, often in fog, with no lights worth trusting. The rule is simple: if a slow border would put us up there after dark, we sleep short of it. If we are on time, the driver continues.

Map — Cumbre de Alaska



Photo: Simon Burchell, CC BY-SA 4.0. Zona 1, near the hotel.

HOTEL, FIVE NIGHTS

Casa Morasan

12 Avenida 8-21, Zona 1, Quetzaltenango. Arrive around 4:00–5:00.

A small hotel in the old center, a few blocks from the park. We stay Wednesday through Sunday and leave at 7:00 on Monday, so we tell them the night before. Rooms get cold. There is no fireplace. The street in the photo is the neighborhood, not the front door.

casamorasan.com

No separate photo.
Use the link.

COFFEEHOUSE AND A HOUSE MUSEUM

Café Museo La Luna

Dinner, if we are hungry after the bus. 8a Avenida 4-11, Zona 1.

An old house a short walk from the hotel. Coffee, chocolate, and a light meal, with thousands of old photographs of the city on the walls. Open Wednesday to Sunday, from 1:00pm. If it is full: La Flor Maya, Giuseppe, Royal Paris, or Cardinali, all in Zona 1. Tecún is the old cantina if we only want a drink.

Map — Café Museo La Luna

Thursday, December 3

The big market, then one look at the lake from above. We sleep in Xela again.

> Leave the hotel at 7:00. Market 9:30–1:00. Sololá lookout 2:00–2:45. Back in Xela 4:30–5:00.



Photo: Toby Argüelles, CC BY-SA 2.0.

THURSDAY MARKET

Chichicastenango

The real market day is Thursday. Sunday is the other one. We are here on the right day.

A K’iche’ town that fills its plaza and the church steps with textiles, vegetables, flowers, and incense. Santo Tomás is the white church at the end of the aisle in the photo. Walk it. Buy one thing if we want. We do not need a guide to understand it, and we do not stay for the afternoon. Lunch is here, before we leave at 1:00.

wikipedia.org/wiki/Chichicastenango



Photo: Bruno Rijsman, CC BY-SA 2.0. The lake from the high road.

LAKE LOOKOUT — DO NOT GO DOWN

Sololá mirador

About 45 minutes. Then we turn around.

This is Lake Atitlán from the rim, the view in the photo. Volcanoes, blue water, towns far below. We look. We do not drive down to Panajachel, and we do not take a boat. The road down eats the rest of the day, and the hotel is back in Xela.

wikipedia.org/wiki/Lake_Atitlán

Dinner back in Xela

Ojalá — a newer place in the center, if the hotel says it is open. No site we trust, so we do not follow a random link.
Royal Paris — French-leaning menu, wine, sometimes live music. 14 Avenida A 3-06, Zona 1. royalparis blog
Cardinali — Italian, in the center for twenty-plus years. 14 Avenida, Zona 1. restaurantecardinali.wordpress.com
A drink after, if we want one: Tecún, the old cantina. Not a late night. Friday starts early.

Friday, December 4

Four small towns in a loop around Xela, then a sunset hill in the city. No long hike today.

> San Francisco El Alto 7:15–10:00. Then San Cristóbal, Totonicapán for lunch, Salcajá, the center of Xela, El Baúl at sunset.



Photo: Simon Burchell, CC BY-SA 3.0.

FRIDAY HILL MARKET

San Francisco El Alto

Above Xela. Friday is their day. Go early.

A market town on a ridge. The plaza in front of the church fills with stalls. Blankets are what the town is known for. The animal market is higher up the hill, and it is mostly over if you arrive late. We are here for the morning, not the whole day.

wikipedia — San Francisco El Alto



Photo: Julitomenchu, CC BY-SA 3.0. A chapel in the churchyard.

COLONIAL CHURCH

San Cristóbal Totonicapán

A short stop between the market and lunch.

A K’iche’ weaving town. The churchyard has small posa chapels like the one in the photo, and a white church behind them. We look at the front, walk one block, and leave. This is not a museum with tickets.

wikipedia — San Cristóbal Totonicapán



Photo: Rodrigobaaz, CC BY-SA 4.0.

WORKSHOPS AND LUNCH

Totonicapán

Friday is not their big market day. That is the point.

The departmental capital. Tuesday and Saturday are the market. On Friday we are here for a loom or a pottery workshop if one is open, then lunch around the park in the photo. If a workshop is shut, the park and a meal are enough. We do not go hunting for a market that is not on.

wikipedia — Totonicapán



Photo: Simon Burchell, CC BY-SA 4.0.

OLDEST CHURCH, THEN A TASTING

Salcajá

Ermita de la Concepción, then rompopo and caldo de frutas.

The little church in the photo is from 1524. It is counted as the first church in Central America. After that, the main street: rompopo is a strong egg-and-rum drink the town is famous for, and caldo de frutas is a hot spiced fruit cup. Taste both. Buy one small bottle if we like it. Do not fill the suitcase.

salcaja.gob.gt — the ermita

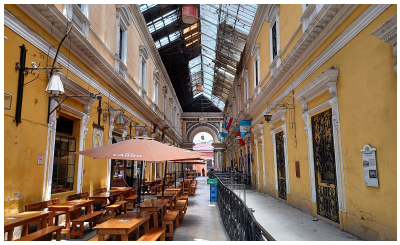


Photo: Simon Burchell, CC BY-SA 4.0.

CITY WALK

Parque Centroamérica and Pasaje Enríquez

Back in Xela, before the hill.

The park with the bandstand is the center of the city. Pasaje Enríquez, in the photo, is the yellow arcade of cafés on one side of it. This is the easy walk: cathedral, the arcade, one coffee. The hotel is a few blocks away.

wikipedia.org/wiki/Quetzaltenango



Photo: Simon Burchell, CC BY-SA 3.0.

SHORT CITY HILL

Cerro El Baúl

Sunset. A lookout, not a trek.

A hill inside the city with a cross and a view over the valley. We drive most of the way and walk the last part. This is the photo: Xela below, mountains behind. We are down before it is fully dark.

wikipedia — Cerro El Baúl

Saturday, December 5

The short hike, then a string of stops in the valley south of town. Trail shoes and the hiking socks. Not the compression socks.

> Cerro Quemado 6:00–7:45. Almolonga 8:00–9:00. Zunil 9:20–10:30. Georginas 11:00–12:30. Las Cumbres 1:15–2:00. Back in Xela about 2:30. The afternoon is free.



Photo: Simon Burchell, CC BY-SA 4.0. The approach, not the summit.

SHORT VOLCANIC HIKE

Cerro Quemado and La Muela

Out early, back before the rest of the day starts.

A lava dome on the west side of Xela. The walk is the short one, from La Muela, not a climb of the tall cone. That tall cone is Santa María, and Santiaguito is the active vent on its side. We are not going there. The photo is the farmland on the way out. The trail itself is pine, dust, and rock. Turn around on time even if the top is close.

wikipedia — Volcán de Cerro Quemado



Photo: Febel3345, CC0.

VEGETABLE VALLEY

Almolonga

Ten minutes south of Xela. A walk, not a hike.

A town that grows vegetables for half of western Guatemala. The photo is the fields. We walk the main street, look at the produce, maybe buy fruit, and leave. Church if it is open. No agenda beyond that hour.

wikipedia — Almolonga



Photo: Sapfan (Jan Pesula), public domain.

SHRINE VISIT

Zunil and Maximón

The cofradía house, then the church if it is open.

Zunil is a K’iche’ town under the volcano. Maximón, also called San Simón, is a dressed figure kept by a local family. The photo is that kind of room: flowers, candles, a hat, a basket. A small gift of a few quetzales is the custom if we go in. Ask before taking a picture. We are visitors, not a tour group.

wikipedia — Zunil



Photo: Kaldari, CC0. We are eating, not swimming.

HOT SPRINGS — EAT AND LOOK

Fuentes Georginas

Cloud forest above Zunil. Lunch. We do not get in the water.

Sulfur pools in a ravine, with a restaurant beside them. The photo is the pools. Our plan is the table and the view. Bring cash: about Q60 each to enter as foreigners, plus about Q25 to park. The road up is narrow. We are back in the car by 12:30.

wikipedia — Fuentes Georginas

No separate photo.
Use the link.

COFFEE AND GARDENS

Las Cumbres

On the road back. 1:15–2:00. WhatsApp +502 5304 2102 if we want a table.

An eco-hotel with steam and hot water for people staying there. We are not staying, and we are not using the spa. Coffee, the gardens, and the view. Then Xela. The rest of Saturday is the cemetery, the Calvario, or a café. Nothing is scheduled after 2:30.

lascumbres.com.gt

Sunday, December 6

The long hike. After that, only what we still feel like doing. This is the big dinner night.

> Leave around 6:00 for Chicabal. Back to Xela by early afternoon. Crafts in the center if we want them. San Andrés Xecul only if our legs are fine. It is 20 minutes from the hotel.



Photo: Simon Burchell, CC BY-SA 4.0.

SACRED CRATER LAKE

Laguna de Chicabal

The hike of the trip. Mam Maya ceremonial site.

A small volcano near San Martín Sacatepéquez. We hike to a round lake in the crater. The photo is the shore in the fog, with flower offerings in the water. Do not swim, do not touch the offerings, and do not walk through a ceremony. Stay on the path. Cash at the community gate. This is why the trail shoes came.

lagunadechicabal.com



Photo: Apoxyomenus, CC BY-SA 4.0.

SUNDAY CRAFTS, IF WE WANT THEM

Back in the center of Xela

Midday, after the hike. Optional.

The same park as the cover photo. On Sunday there are craft stalls around the center. This is a browse, not another Chichicastenango. If the hike was enough, we skip it and sit down.

wikipedia.org/wiki/Quetzaltenango



Photo: Simon Burchell, CC BY-SA 4.0.

PAINTED CHURCH — ONLY IF WE WANT

San Andrés Xecul

Twenty minutes from the hotel. A photo stop, not a hike.

The yellow church in the photo, covered in folk painting: angels, corn, jaguars, the sun. We stand in the plaza, look, maybe go inside if it is open, and leave. If Chicabal used up the day, we do not go. It will still be yellow next time.

wikipedia.org/wiki/San_Andrés_Xecul

Dinner

This is the meal we dress up a little for. Royal Paris or Cardinali, whichever we did not use on Thursday. Links are on Thursday's page. Home early enough that Monday's 7:00 departure is not a punishment.

Monday, December 7

Leave Xela, two hours in Antigua, then the bus. No lake. No Xecul. Compression socks again.

> Out of the hotel at 7:00. Antigua 10:15–12:15. Holiday Inn Zona 10 by 1:15. Pullmantur Primera at 2:00pm. San Benito around 7:30.



Photo: Adalberto H. Vega, CC BY 3.0.

COLONIAL CITY, TWO HOURS

Antigua Guatemala

One coffee, the streets, and one shop. Then we leave.

The old capital, under a volcano. The yellow arch in the photo is Santa Catalina, the picture everyone takes. We walk, we drink one coffee, and we do not add a second neighborhood. The bus will not wait.

wikipedia.org/wiki/Antigua_Guatemala

No separate photo.
Use the link.

JADE MUSEUM AND A SHOP

Casa del Jade

4a Calle Oriente 10, inside a 16th-century house called El Jaulón.

A small museum of Maya jade and a jewelry shop in the same building. This is the "one stop" in Antigua. Look at the stone, buy something only if we actually want it. Open about 9:30–6:30. We need to be gone by 12:15.

casadeljade.com

No separate photo.
Use the link.

BUS HOME

Pullmantur, Primera, 2:00pm

Holiday Inn, 1a Avenida 13-22, Zona 10. Be in the lobby at 1:15.

Same bus company as Wednesday, opposite direction. About five hours, including the border. DUI again. We get off at the Sheraton Presidente in San Benito, around 7:30. Do not book a later bus. This is the one that gets us home the same night.

pullmantur.com

Numbers

Pullmantur — WhatsApp +503 7736-9490. Sheraton Presidente, San Benito, and Holiday Inn Zona 10.
Casa Morasan — +502 7765 0616 and +502 5828 1232. 12 Avenida 8-21, Zona 1.
Las Cumbres — WhatsApp +502 5304 2102, if we want the coffee table held.
Laguna de Chicabal — +502 5706 3620. The community association at the gate.
Driver — private, not a shared shuttle. The number goes on this page once he is booked.

Shoes, in one line

Wednesday and Monday: compression socks, town shoes. Saturday and Sunday: trail shoes and the Hike 500 socks. The other days: normal shoes.

Cash, in one line

The driver, Georginas, and Chicabal want cash. The hotel and the bus tickets go on a card. Do not change dollars at the border.

Photos are from Wikimedia Commons and credited on each page. Place pages are the operator’s own site where one exists, and Wikipedia where it does not. Hours and entrance fees move. Check Georginas and Las Cumbres the week before we go.